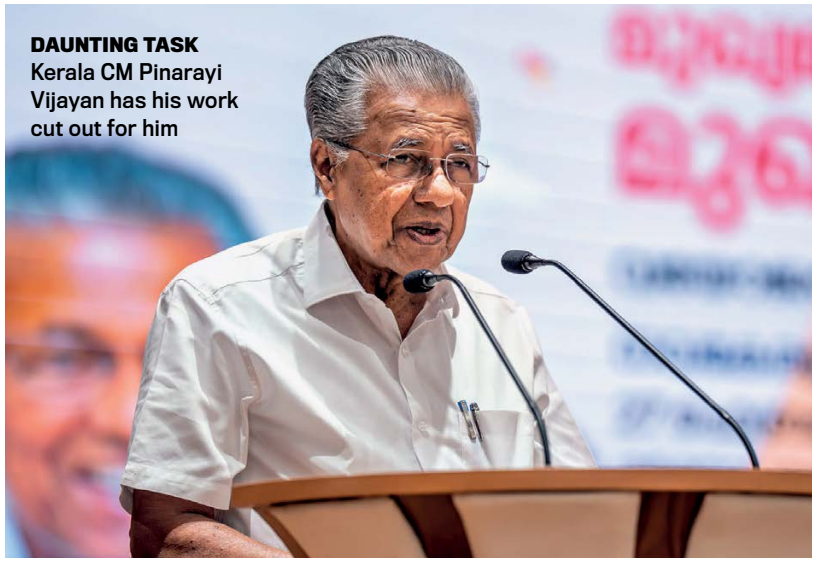


DAUNTING TASK
Kerala CM Pinarayi Vijayan has his work cut out for him

lies not in the numbers alone, but in the underlying shift of its traditional voter base. Perhaps the most alarming aspect of this electoral defeat is the apparent erosion of support among the Ezhavas, a numerically crucial OBC community. Comprising about 23 per cent of Kerala's population, the Ezhavas have long been loyal to the Left. But the 2024 election saw a significant portion of this community gravitating towards the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), challenging long-held political assumptions.

This shift was particularly evident in constituencies such as Attingal, Alappuzha, Pathanamthitta, Chalakudy, Thrissur, Palakkad, Alathur, Vadakara and Kannur. In Attingal, for instance, the CPI(M)'s V. Joy lost to sitting Congress MP Adoor Prakash by a mere 684 votes, mainly as the BJP's V. Muraleedharan, who came third, cornered a substantial 311,779 votes. Similar patterns were observed in other constituencies, indicating a broader trend of Ezhava voters realigning their political preferences. The shift is not limited to the Ezhavas alone. Other communities, including the Dheevaras (grouping of fishing castes) and even sections of the Muslim and Christian population, have shown signs of moving away from the Left, further complicating the political equation for the CPI(M).

Recognising the gravity of the situation, the CPI(M) convened a crucial meeting of its state secretariat and state committee from June 17 to 19, with party general secretary Sitaram Yechurry and his predecessor Prakash Karat in attendance. It was here that the Pinarayi government was told to pull up its socks. M.V. Govindan Master, the CPI(M) state secretary, addressing the media on June 20, enumerated several factors contributing to the party's poor performance. These include the consolidation of minority votes in favour of the Congress, the influence of the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) constituent Bharath Dharma Jana Sena (BDJS) in swaying Ezhava votes towards the BJP, alleged negative campaigns run by the Malayalam media against the government and a general sentiment favouring the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA). "We will take appropriate steps and corrective measures to win back the people's mandate," Govindan said, drawing parallels to the party's resurgence between the 2019 Lok Sabha and the 2021 assembly polls. "We don't feel that the entire game is lost. We will act democratically and go forward with people-friendly programmes."



"We don't feel that the entire game is lost. We will act democratically and go forward with people-friendly programmes...to win back the people's mandate"

M.V. GOVINDAN MASTER
CPI(M) state secretary, Kerala

The CPI(M) now faces the daunting task of recalibrating its strategy to regain lost ground before the 2026 assembly election. The burden of this responsibility falls heavily on Pinarayi, whose previous strategy of relying on Muslim support seems to have fallen short. The party must also contend with an increasingly complex political landscape. The Congress, buoyed by its recent success and the potential entry of Priyanka Gandhi as a candidate from Wayanad Lok Sabha seat (vacated by her brother Rahul), is likely to present a formidable challenge. Simultaneously, the BJP's growing appeal adds another dimension to the electoral equation.

A senior CPI(M) leader, speaking on the condition of anonymity, admitted to serious flaws in the party's political apparatus. "More than losing our traditional vote bank, the party has lost the political mechanism to estimate responses and take rectifying measures," the leader confessed, highlighting a systemic failure in both governance and party organisation. The CPI(M)'s ability to navigate these challenges will not only determine its political future in Kerala but also have broader implications for the Left movement in India. The coming months will reveal whether the party can craft a new narrative that resonates with the aspirations of a changing electorate, or if it will fade into political irrelevance, mirroring its fate in West Bengal. ■